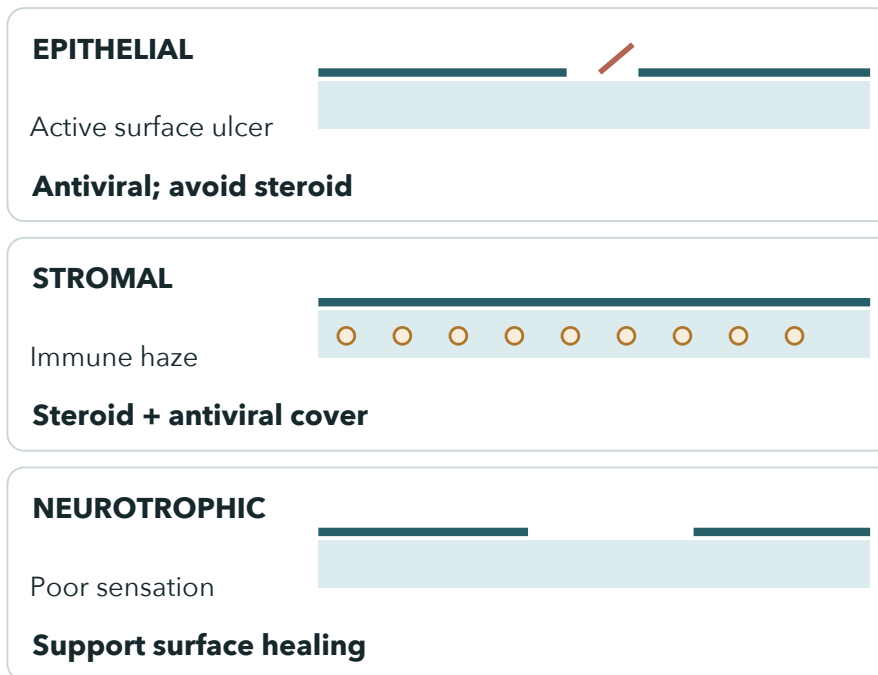


HSV: infection, inflammation or healing failure?

The affected compartment decides how steroid is used.

Locate the active process

A | Same virus, different compartments



Original corneal sections. The intact epithelium in immune stromal disease is the key distinction from an active epithelial ulcer.

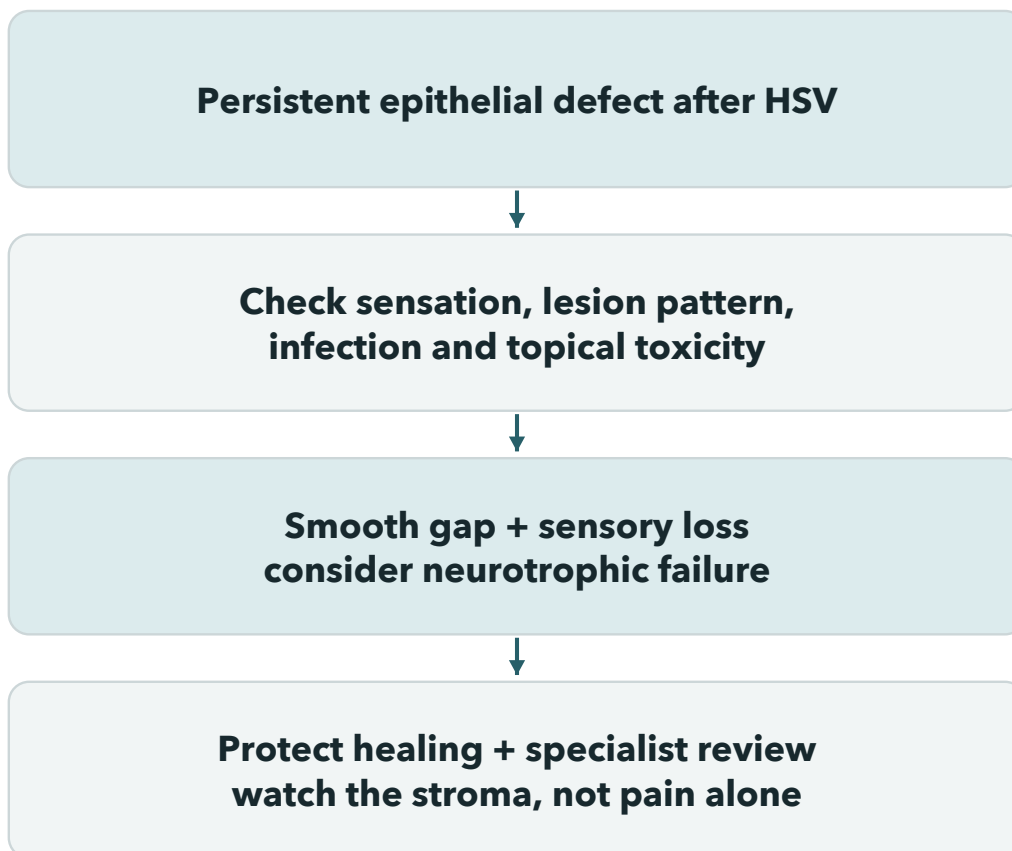
Read the fluorescein and stroma

Pattern	Treatment principle
Dendrite or geographic ulcer	Antiviral treatment; avoid topical steroid in active epithelial disease.
Immune stromal haze; intact surface	Supervised topical steroid with antiviral cover, monitored taper and pressure checks.
Smooth persistent defect; low sensation	Reassess for neurotrophic failure and toxicity after excluding active infection.
New infiltrate or thinning	Urgent re-evaluation for superinfection, active necrosis or melting.

References AAO EyeWiki | Epithelial HSV keratitis | AAO EyeWiki | Stromal HSV and endotheliitis | AAO EyeWiki | Neurotrophic keratitis

A nonhealing surface is a different question

B | Do not keep treating the old label



Original reassessment flow. Viral infection, immune inflammation and denervation can coexist; the clinician reassesses which is active.

Protect healing

Corneal sensation is part of the assessment. Little pain with a persistent defect can reflect denervation, not recovery. Review frequent or toxic topical drugs and maintain stage-appropriate lubrication and protection under the cornea team. Advanced defects may need additional healing treatment or closure procedures. Continue antiviral prophylaxis when indicated, but do not equate indefinite intensive topical antiviral with improved epithelial healing. Re-examine promptly if the defect enlarges or the stroma thins. For example, a resolved dendrite followed by a smooth painless gap and severe sensory loss needs a fresh healing assessment. In contrast, immune stromal haze under an intact surface may require steroid with antiviral cover. The earlier diagnosis does not settle today's treatment.

References AAO EyeWiki | Epithelial HSV keratitis | AAO EyeWiki | Neurotrophic keratitis | AAO EyeWiki | Stromal HSV and endotheliitis